The Marvel Method: Production Doctrine

Volume 17 — **locked**. These rules govern how every MCU film and series is physically made, from *Iron Man* (2008) onward. In the real-world story they become known across the industry as **“the Marvel Method.”**

#	Rule	In practice
1	**100% practical, including sets.** VFX and CGI only when necessary.	Real built sets, real suits, real props, real fire, miniatures, animatronics and in-camera effects. Digital effects are used only for what physically can't be filmed: flight, a full-size Hulk, cosmic powers, planets, and erasing safety rigs.
2	**100% on location.** Soundstages only when necessary.	Filming happens where the story happens: New York for New York, real deserts, real military bases, real cities. Stages are used only when a location is impossible, unsafe or doesn't exist, such as an active war zone, a fire-filled cave interior, or the halls of Asgard.
3	**Actors perform their own stunts**, including motion capture when necessary.	Every actor trains for months and performs their own action. Professional stunt performers stay on every production as coordinators, trainers, rehearsal partners and safety teams, at full rates. Characters made with motion capture are performed by their own actors: Amond Baker plays the Hulk, Josh Brolin plays Thanos.

What It Means on Screen

- **Iron Man:** Stan Winston Studio's wearable armors (the 90-pound Mark I, Mark II and Mark III) are worn by Marc-Anthony himself. ILM adds flight and the transformations.
- **Hulk:** Amond performs the Hulk in a motion-capture suit *on location*, in the real streets, with practical prosthetics for the stages of his transformation. That gives digital effects a real performance and real light to match.
- **Thor:** Esther trains in hammer combat with a weighted, practical Mjolnir. Lightning is added with effects, but the wind, rain and wreckage around her are real.
- **Street-level heroes:** Black Widow, Hawkeye, Captain America and Bucky do real fight choreography, wire work and archery, done by the actors.

Where Chapter Two fits: the *Iron Man* cave is a **practical set built on a stage**, because live blowtorches and real fire can't safely be used inside a natural cave. That's the “only when necessary” exception. The rest of the film shoots on location: the Lone Pine desert (standing in for Afghanistan, since filming in an active war zone is impossible), Edwards Air Force Base, the Malibu coast, and the Donohue Concert Hall in downtown L.A.

Drama for the Real-World Story

- **The insurance war:** the companies that insure productions balk at actors doing their own stunts. Lenora Hayes fights for every policy, and premiums jump.
- **Budgets and schedules:** practical work and location shooting cost more and take longer, while Merrill Lynch watches every dollar. Rival studios call it vanity, until the results arrive.
- **The stunt community:** stunt performers worry about their jobs at first. Marvel's answer is to hire them as coordinators and trainers on every film at full rates. That builds an alliance and wins respect across the industry.
- **Injuries and grit:** bruises, sprains and the occasional scare on set give the story real stakes, plus the pride of an entire cast that can say “that was really me.”

- **The legend:** behind-the-scenes clips and DVD featurettes (and later YouTube) make “they really did it” part of the MCU brand. Fans start counting practical shots the way they count Easter eggs.